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From black to green with a dash of New Nordic

The multimodal rebranding of a Danish energy company with global aspirations

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From Black to Green with a Dash of New Nordic. The Multimodal Rebranding of a Danish Energy Company with Global Aspirations

Introduction

With the current global focus on climate change and environmental degradation, these topics feature high on the list of issues that are incorporated into the business strategies of many companies today. A case in point is Danish energy company DONG Energy (now Ørsted), which has recently gone through a strategic transformation from black to green energy, divesting its upstream oil and gas production and aiming to phase out coal by 2023. While previously state-owned, the company was publicly listed in 2016 and is currently expanding globally with operations in Europe, the US and Asia. The company's black activities have been substituted by offshore and onshore wind farms, bioenergy plants and waste-to-energy solutions. As an integrated part of this green transition, the company introduced a new name, logo and brand identity in 2017, developed through an extensive two-year collaboration between a creative in-house team at DONG Energy, the Scandinavian design agency Kontrapunkt and the international advertising agency Wieden+Kennedy. The result is a consistent well-designed brand image, pivoting around green energy. As proclaimed by Chairman of the Board of Directors at DONG Energy, Thomas Thune Andersen, on launching the new brand:

> Our vision is a world that runs entirely on green energy. Climate change is one of the most serious challenges facing the world today, and to avoid causing serious harm to the global ecosystems, we need to fundamentally change the way we power the world by switching from black to green energy. (Announcement, 02.10.2017)

When a large energy company converts its production from black to green energy it is obviously good for the climate and the environment and in tune with the UN Sustainable Development Goals. To the extent that DONG Energy's green transition into Ørsted is also motivated by Corporate Social Responsibility strategies (CSR), such strategies are clearly aligned with the company's core business, since the transition has a direct impact on the environment and the climate. In contrast to other players on the energy market such as Shell and BP, who have justly been accused of greenwashing (e.g. Greer and Bruno 1996; Kassinis and Panayiotou 2017), Ørsted appears to *walk* their CSR *talk* with regard to sustainability (cf. Wickert and Cornelissen 2017; Bowen 2014). However, as pointed out

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by Reich (2007, 170) in his critique of the relationship between contemporary capitalism and democracy and the role of CSR in that respect, "the soothing promise of responsibility can deflect public attention from the need for stricter laws and regulations or convince the public that there is no real problem to begin with." Taking up Reich's observation, I would argue that it is furthermore imperative that well-executed corporate brands are not allowed to divert attention from serious issues that need to be handled and that Multimodal Critical Discourse Analysis offers useful tools for assessing corporate communication in that respect.

This article critically examines the Ørsted brand image as it is presented on the company's websites and in the corporate discourse surrounding the brand, pointing to tensions between Ørsted's proclaimed green ideology and the corporate interests according to which a listed company must ultimately navigate. For Ørsted, this complex reality is one in which the new brand strategy gives pronounced emphasis to a green image and environmental concerns while, at the same time, the company needs to signal financial accountability to its different stakeholders and appeal to consumers more generally. It is also a reality that involves a certain tension between the local and the global, with Ørsted a Danish company entering the global market. Through critical social semiotic multimodal analysis, the article investigates how the new brand image is realised through wording, typography, colour and images. Analytical attention is devoted to the concept of *discourse* presented by van Leeuwen (2005) and the claim that different discourses construct different versions of reality and consequently reflect different ideas, values, interests and identities (see also Machin and Mayr 2012¸ Machin 2013). The analysis reveals how three different discourses – a sustainability discourse, a corporate profits discourse and a New Nordic discourse – are centrally involved in the brand image, and it is argued that these discourses reflect the complex reality Ørsted is navigating as well as the corporate interests of the company.

Analytical approach

My analysis of the Ørsted brand is theoretically and methodologically grounded in multimodal social semiotics (e.g. Kress and van Leeuwen 2006, 2001; van Leeuwen 2005) and the critical approach to communication within that field of Multimodal Critical Discourse Analysis, MCDA (e.g. van Leeuwen 2008; Machin and Mayr 2012; Machin 2013). In social semiotics, meaning-making is seen as a decidedly social phenomenon and is consequently examined in the specific social and cultural context(s) in which it occurs. Language and other communicative resources (or "modes") such as

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images, colour and typography are regarded not as signs systems with fixed meaning, but as semiotic resources that communicators can draw on and adapt to reach their own communicative goals. It is characteristic of the social semiotic approach to meaning-making that the different resources are systematised and described in detail (e.g. Kress and van Leeuwen 2006 on images; van Leeuwen 1999 on sound; van Leeuwen 2011 on colour; van Leeuwen 2006 on typography; Bateman 2008 on layout; Ravelli and McMurtrie 2016 on the built environment), thereby facilitating consistent detailed analysis of the use of individual resources and their multimodal integration in texts. With the focus on social aspects of human signifying practices comes a concern with the ways in which different interests and ideologies are realised by all texts. This aspect of communication is particularly emphasised in MCDA, where analysis invariably seeks to uncover the interests, ideologies and power relations that are ingrained in communication (Machin and Mayr 2012, 24-26).

The concept of *discourse* is pivotal to MCDA and to the analysis of Ørsted's new brand presented below. In my use of the concept, I follow van Leeuwen's definition of discourse (2005, 94, which, in turn, builds on Foucault 1977) as "socially constructed knowledges of some aspect of reality." To explain this, van Leeuwen makes an illuminating example of the "object" of war and how it can be represented and thus constructed in different ways by means of different discourses:

> there can be and are several different ways of knowing – and hence also of representing – the same "object" of knowledge. That object exists of course. There *are* wars and they *do* cause enormous suffering. But our knowledge of them is necessarily constructed in and through discourse, and is socially specific. This also means that the same individual can have different knowledges of the same object, and may well be able to talk about the same war in several different ways, depending on the situation as well as on his or her own individual interests and purposes. (2005, 94)

In MCDA as in CDA (e.g. Fairclough 2003), analysts thus critically investigate how reality is transformed into discourse, and hence how discourse constructs different versions of reality. On a general level, the elements involved in actual social practices (actors, actions, time, space, etc., cf. van Leeuwen 2005, 106-8) can be either *included* or *excluded* when a given real-life situation is transformed into discourse. The elements that are included can furthermore be made more or less prominent, i.e. *foregrounded* or *backgrounded* (Fairclough 2003, 135-37). In addition, reality can be transformed into discourse through *addition* (often of *explanations*, *legitimations* and *evaluations*), *substitution* (e.g. *abstraction* and *objectification*) and *rearrangements* (e.g. *imposing order* where

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none exists and vice versa) (Fairclough 2003, 134-55; van Leeuwen 2005, 102-12, 2008; Machin 2013).

In my analysis, I will show how three different discourses are centrally involved in the Ørsted brand: 1) a sustainability discourse focusing on the advantages to the environment of the company's green transition; 2) a corporate profits discourse focusing on the financial advantages of the green transition to Ørsted and its partners, shareholders, etc.; and 3) a New Nordic discourse by means of which Ørsted appears to tap into a popular Northern European branding trend and to navigate issues related to the company's local and global involvements. My analysis aims to capture how these discourses are realised by multimodal means and consider the corporate concerns they reflect. While primarily focusing on the Ørsted brand as it is presented on the company's websites, the analysis also considers how the brand is talked about (cf. van Leeuwen 2005, 3) by Ørsted managers and those involved in designing the new brand. This is done to show how these discourses manifest particular aspects of the brand while excluding others, thereby revealing the corporate interests behind the brand. Throughout, I maintain a critical perspective, seeking to "reveal the kinds of ideas, absences and taken-for-granted assumptions in the images as well as in the texts which will also serve the ends of revealing the kinds of power interests buried in them" (Machin and Mayr 2012, 9-10).

Where two of the discourses put up for scrutiny – the sustainability discourse and the corporate profits discourse – are self-explanatory, the concept of the "New Nordic" warrants further explanation.[1] Briefly summarized, the concept first flourished with the New Nordic Kitchen in the noughties. The New Nordic Cuisine Movement favours local produce, puts emphasis on sustainability, animal welfare and sound production and involves a pronounced focus on Nordic nature and climate. Following the international success of the New Nordic in the culinary world, the concept quickly began to gain currency in the design world where it is often used for marketing purposes, especially in relation to furniture and home accessories where values such as functionality, durability, craftmanship, authenticity, quality, affordable luxury and increasingly also sustainability are emphasised. The growing interest in "just about anything remotely Nordic" (Stougaard-Nielsen 2016, 5) is seen also in the booming international success of Nordic TV series and crime novels (Stougaard-Nielsen 2016) and the recent British infatuation with Danish "hygge" (Breunig and Kallestrup 2020).

With the New Nordic comes a distinctive visual and material discourse characterised by simplicity, minimalist design, clean lines, geometric forms, a colour palette consisting primarily of white, light and pale colours, natural materials and textures, space, air and light. As indicated by the

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brief description above, the connection to green thinking and sustainability is also present in the New Nordic trend, if sometimes only vaguely so.

In my analysis of the Ørsted brand, I will show how the three discourses – the sustainability discourse, the corporate profits discourse and the New Nordic discourse – are realised by specific semiotic choices and their multimodal interaction. I will focus primarily on the semiotic resources of wording, typography, colour and images and simultaneously consider how the meanings created also come about as a result of discursive inclusion, exclusion, addition and substitution. I conclude my analysis with critical observations about a number of more general issues that are arguably excluded from the new brand image as it is presented online and the nonetheless predominantly positive reactions to the new brand in the media.

Wording

Name

Changing the name of a large, well-stablished company like DONG Energy is a strong rebranding signal; but doing so is not risk-free and the motivations behind a name change are therefore usually very strong. DONG is an acronym of "Dansk Olie og Naturgas" (Eng. "Danish Oil and Natural Gas"), and in the official announcement (02.10.2017) of the new brand identity, Chairman of the Board of Directors, Thomas Thune Andersen, explained the name change by "DONG"'s reference to oil and natural gas being inconsistent with the green transition of the company. This message was extensively repeated in the associated branding campaign and on the new website (https://orsted.com/en/Explore/About-our-name-change) and was clearly the narrative the company wished to promote. While other circumstances seemed to make a name change convenient, too, they were largely absent (i.e. *exclusion*) from the company's official narrative. Although the reference of the acronym to a Danish context did not accord with Ørsted's wish to expand its activities outside Denmark, for instance, this information was not included in the company's discursive motivation for the name change. On the contrary, Thomas Thune Andersen, made a point of emphasising and thereby foregrounding that "Ørsted is a signal of our Danish roots" (Announcement 30.10.2017). Another possible motivation behind the name change that is excluded from the corporate discourse about the new name concerns the convenience of discarding a name that had come to carry negative connotations because of the sale in 2014 of an 18% stake in DONG Energy to a subsidiary of the American multinational investment bank Goldman Sachs, known for its role in the global financial crisis (2007-08) and for shifting earnings to tax havens. The sale was highly controversial and caused

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public as well as political protests, culminating in six cabinet ministers withdrawing from the Danish coalition government. Changing name and not mentioning the Goldman Sachs affair in the process is, of course, understandable and presumably reflects corporate interests in toning down this chapter of the company history. Finally, with "dong" being an English slang term for "penis", the management and brand designers at DONG Energy probably also saw the advantage of changing what was a rather unfortunate name for a company with global aspirations. This motivation for the name change is not mentioned explicitly on the website or by the corporate discourse about the name change but is hinted at by one of the posters in the branding campaign which carried the following message (in English): "We are changing our name to Ørsted. Because when you hear 'DONG' your first thought isn't green energy."

While various circumstances may thus have motivated the name change, the green transition of the company is foregrounded as the all-important reason for the change in the corporate discourse surrounding the new brand identity. But how 'green' is the new name really? According to a DONG Energy announcement (02.10.2017), the choice of "Ørsted" is a tribute to Danish scientist, Hans Christian Ørsted (1777-1851) who discovered electromagnetism, the principle behind electric power production. Through the new name, the company borrows ethos from the scientist, however the energy spent on the website explaining (in text, images and video) who Ørsted was appears to reflect a concern that he might not be known widely enough for the intended connotations of the name to be recognised. As for the name's connotations of 'greenness' and 'sustainability', the biographical information provided about the scientist accentuates his interest in nature and consequent relevance for the company's green transition. Altogether, a fair amount of meta-discourse is employed to establish how the new name aligns with the new green identity of the company and the discursive strategies of explanation and legitimation play a significant role in this respect.

If the reference to Ørsted the scientist is not clear to customers, stakeholders and others abroad, the use of the letter "ø" is likely to be immediately more meaningful in a global context because of its specifically Nordic flavour and its consequent signification of 'Nordicness.' For a company with global aspirations to change its name to one that has a distinctively local ring to it might seem an odd choice. Some critics regarded this as Ørsted's attempt to rid itself of the negative connotations of the old name that resulted from its association with Goldman Sachs. Such criticism is dismissed by Ørsted Head of Communications, Martin Barlebo, who, when interviewed about the new brand name,

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discursively reconstructs the Goldman Sachs controversy through abstraction and negative evaluation as "myths and misunderstandings":

> We have not changed our name to make people forget that we have been a big oil company or because Goldman Sachs have had owner's shares in the company. The myths and misunderstandings that followed the capital increase [i.e. the sale of shares to Goldman Sachs] will stick many years from now. (Kamp 2018, my translation)

Later in the interview, Barlebo makes a point of discursively constructing the new name as 'green' by stating that the choice of a distinctively Scandinavian name is motivated by the idea that abroad "Scandinavian" carries the meaning of 'green energy' and 'sustainability' (i.e. *addition*: *explanation*). What might seem an odd local name for a company entering the global scene thus appears to be a deliberate attempt to tap into the New Nordic discourse that is gaining global currency in many strands of life in the hope that it will trigger associations of sustainability. Whether these connotations of the name are strong enough to be picked up by customers, stakeholders, etc. is another matter.

Website menus

Another meaning-making making aspect of the Ørsted website concerns the wording that gets to be included in its navigation bar. Although website menus are typically organised according to functional principles (of usability and managing user-behaviour), they are far from neutral sites of ideological meaning. In itself, the top menu is a site of importance since this is where users navigate the website and since only a small number of items will fit into the limited space available. Added to this, established web conventions mean that the beginning of the navigation bar is a privileged position and that items placed to the left in horizontally organised top menus are presented as more important than those to the right simply by their placement (see also Djonov and van Leeuwen 2013 on the role of templates in establishing hierarchies of importance in webpage design). Consequently, this placement may be considered a subtle example of evaluation.

Most of Ørsted's website menu bars reflect (and help construct) the company's new green identity because of the green items they contain and the horizontal organisation of these items in their layout. Initially, "Sustainability" was given a prominent place as the second menu item to the left of the navigation bar of orsted.com, only outmatched by "Our business" in first position. Since then, the order and contents of the menu have been changed so that at the moment of writing (summer 2020),

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no less than three menu items out of six are concerned with green issues ("Act now", "Green solutions" and "Sustainability") and are given the prominent position as the first three items of the navigation bar (Figure 1, https://orsted.com/en/our-business). Similarly, the UK, German, Dutch, US and Taiwan sites all have items in their main menu that refer explicitly to green energy: "Clean growth," "Green energy solutions," "EnergieWinde," "Groene energie," "Solar and storage," etc. The wording that is included in the navigation bar and the organisation of the bar are clear signals about the priorities of the company. Where, initially, the website menu of orsted.com underscored the value of green issues while simultaneously signalling that business comes first, the recently updated top menu ascribes even more value to green issues by the increased number of green menu items and the placement of these as the thee most important items in the navigation bar.



Figure 1. Ørsted website menu.

Running text

That green issues are important, but that business comes first is communicated by the running text on Ørsted webpages that specifically address potential business customers. Here talk of green energy often goes hand in hand with comments about the profitability of green growth in terms of economic growth, CSR profile and shareholder value. This is exemplified by the following extracts from orstedbusiness.co.uk, where the sustainability discourse (underlined) is intimately hooked up with and thereby legitimised by a corporate profits discourse (in bold):

> By creating **market leading** energy solutions and **driving down the cost** of renewable energy, we're helping UK businesses move towards a greener, more sustainable energy future. Renewable energy is **now a commercially sound decision** for any business.
>
> We offer UK businesses renewable electricity **at no extra cost**, allowing you to contribute to a greener future **without impacting your budget**.
>
> We're helping businesses to be smart with their energy consumption **to reduce costs, meet their carbon reduction targets and CSR commitments**.
>
> (orstedbusiness.co.uk/en/About-us/Our-vision, accessed 20.11.2019)

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Notwithstanding examples like the above, it is, in fact, characteristic of Ørsted's self-representation online that talk of profits is backgrounded and indirectly communicated as exemplified in the following passage about market expansion on orsted.com:

> We have by far the largest capacity, the deepest technical competencies and the biggest pipeline of all offshore wind developers, and we have consequently been first in introducing the next generation of wind turbines. Until 2020, we will be constructing another six major offshore wind farms. Once operational, these wind farms will bring clean energy to millions of people, as well as contribute to a greener, healthier future for us all. (https://orsted.com/en/Our-business/Offshore-wind/Market-expansion, accessed 20.05.2020)

While having "the largest capacity", "the deepest technical competencies", "the biggest pipeline", being "first" and "bring[ing] clean energy to millions of people" are evaluative statements about skills, capacity and productivity, they also hold implications about profit performance as a likely result of these positive characteristics. However, profits are not actually mentioned, and the preliminary notes of a profits discourse quickly turn into a sustainability discourse about "clean energy" and "a greener, healthier future for us all."

Typography

The development of the new Ørsted brand involved the design of a custom-made typeface that would play a central role in the company's new visual identity. The typeface is a geometric sans-serif typeface, which is characterised by lack of contrast and tension (cf. Stötzner 2003, 291) and has a modern look to it. While the typeface might equally well bring associations of European typographic modernism, the Kontrapunkt designers of the typeface make a point of discursively constructing it as Nordic by verbal as well as visual means on their own website about the Ørsted redesign. Here, the verbal text explains that "[t]he bespoke typeface is inspired by early 20th century Nordic modernist typefaces", while a video mood-board shows a collage of four typographic examples, of which three are unmistakably Danish/Nordic because of their specific wording and the occurrence of the letter "ø" (Figure 2, www.kontrapunkt.com/work/orsted/, accessed 20.05.2020).

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Figure 2. Kontrapunkt's collage of typographic examples.

A striking feature of the Ørsted typeface, which sets it apart from similar typefaces, is the characteristic curvature of the letters "g", "k", "v", "w" and "y" (cf. Figure 3). This may be considered a subtle indexical typographic representation (Nørgaard 2019, 82) of the wind having whizzed through the text. At least, this is how the Kontrapunkt designers would like viewers to make sense of the typeface to judge from their own description of it as "geometric and easy to read with details and shapes inspired by wind" (www.kontrapunkt.com/work/orsted/). The typeface arguably also has a certain 'airiness' to it because of the weight of its strokes – particularly of the light version of the typeface that is often used for subheadings on the Ørsted website. This 'airiness' is, in fact, a multimodal construct, co-realised by the typography and the layout of the webpages, which is typically characterised by very broad margins. However tempting it might seem to delve into interpretations of these aspects of the Ørsted website as representative of wind and air – in line with Kontrapunkt's discursive construction (through *explanation*) of that meaning of the typeface above – it should be noted that, strictly speaking, the visual look of the website layout and typography is very similar to many other current corporate websites, against the backdrop of which only the curving letters and the light weight of the subheadings stand out.

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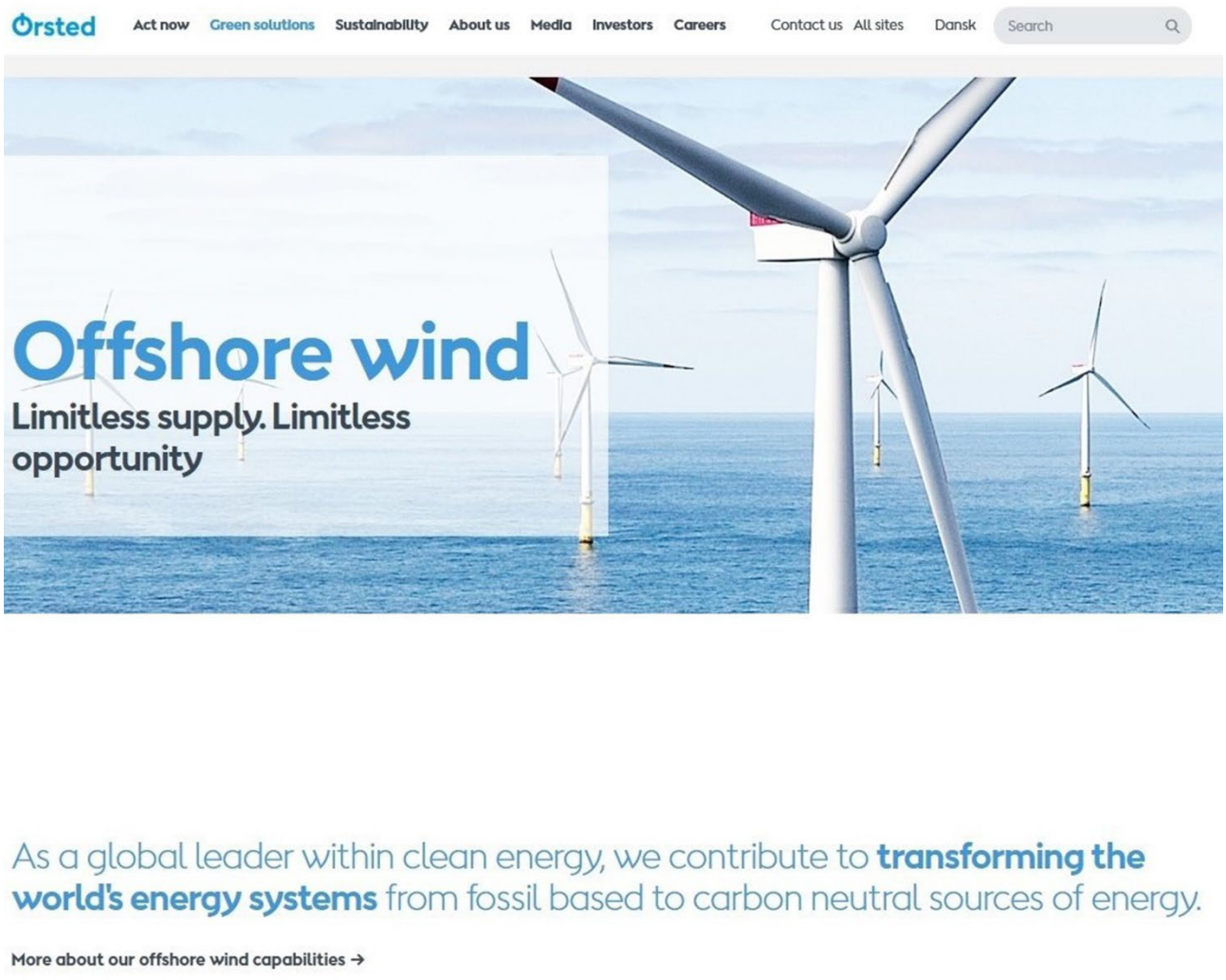


Figure 3. Representative screen shot from the Ørsted website (see colours in online version of this article).

The most striking feature of the custom-made typeface resides in the special "ø" of the Ørsted logo (cf. Figure 1). The logo consists of the company name and the abstract form of its first letter has a clear iconic similarity to the well-known power bottom icon which is here imported discursively into a context where it did not previously belong (Nørgaard 2019, 80-82) – a particularly apt choice for the logo of a company that produces and sells electricity. While this typographic choice plays no role in the multimodal construction of Ørsted's green identity, the designers at Kontrapunkt accentuate the accordance of this choice with the Nordic identity of the brand through their visual meta-discourse about the brand, which displays the usage of a similarly shaped "ø" in a Danish context (cf. Figure 2).

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Colour

Together with the typography, the colour and images are the most important constitutive elements of Ørsted's visual identity online. The colour scheme of the new brand consists of light blue, light turquoise, subdued yellow, coral, grey and plum, with light blue being the dominant colour on most of the webpages. In combination with the light typography and the airy layout, the light blue colour creates a certain visual lightness of the website. It also rhymes visually (Kress and van Leeuwen 2006, 204) with the website's many photographs – especially of off-shore wind farms – which are dominated by blue sky and sea (cf. Figure 3). Arguably, the connection thus created between the light blue colour and the experiential contents of the images enforces the meaning potential of the website's blue colour as an abstract (iconic) blue of the sky and the sea in this particular context. Furthermore, the visual rhyme and the sheer amount of light blue add visual weight and semantic prominence to these signifiers (i.e. sky, sea and windmills), thereby contributing to the brand's sustainability discourse. At the same time however, blue is also a well-known corporate colour and hence a "safe" choice in a corporate context, which thus arguably also participates in the construction of the corporate profits discourse – even if only very subtly so.

The bright colours contrast with the colour scheme of the old DONG Energy logo and visual identity, which was characterised by red and black. In an interview about the new brand, Louise Ryberg, Ørsted Head of Design, remarks:

> When we did an analysis on our existing colours, even the yellow had black in it. […] They couldn't tell the visual story of DONG without using black ink. It was too funny, this oil and gas company, and every colour has black in it. Even the yellow. So the first thing we decided was we'll have *bright* colours. Without *any* black. And because our brand is inspired by Danish functionalism, we looked at other colours used in that period. (Heron 2017; italics in original)

Here – as in Kontrapunkt's mood board video and Ørsted's own discourse about the new design below – it is explicitly underscored and hence foregrounded that the colours of the new design are inspired by "the Danish design tradition" and "Danish functionalism". In the mood board video, this is furthermore done by illustrating the colour palette through a collage of photographs of Danish

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architecture, Danish design furniture and a modernist painting by a Danish artist. In the announcement of the new name and brand identity (02.10.2017), "nature" is added to the equation:

> As part of becoming Ørsted, a new logo and brand identity will be introduced. The new brand identity is inspired by the Danish design tradition in being simple, functional and human and supporting a sustainable way of life. The brand identity will consist of a full spectrum of colours, inspired by Scandinavian nature and the Danish 20th century artist Vilhelm Lundstrøm.

The official discourse by Ørsted and Kontrapunkt about the new brand thus combines references to the Danish design tradition, functionalism, sustainability and nature the way it is often seen in New Nordic branding. As revealed by the blog post of "Nordic Design News" displayed in Figure 4 (nordicdesignnews.com/article/view/312026/new_nordic_colours_from_pytt_living, accessed 02.07.2019), Ørsted is simply drawing on what is already an established popular colour scheme in New Nordic lifestyle marketing.

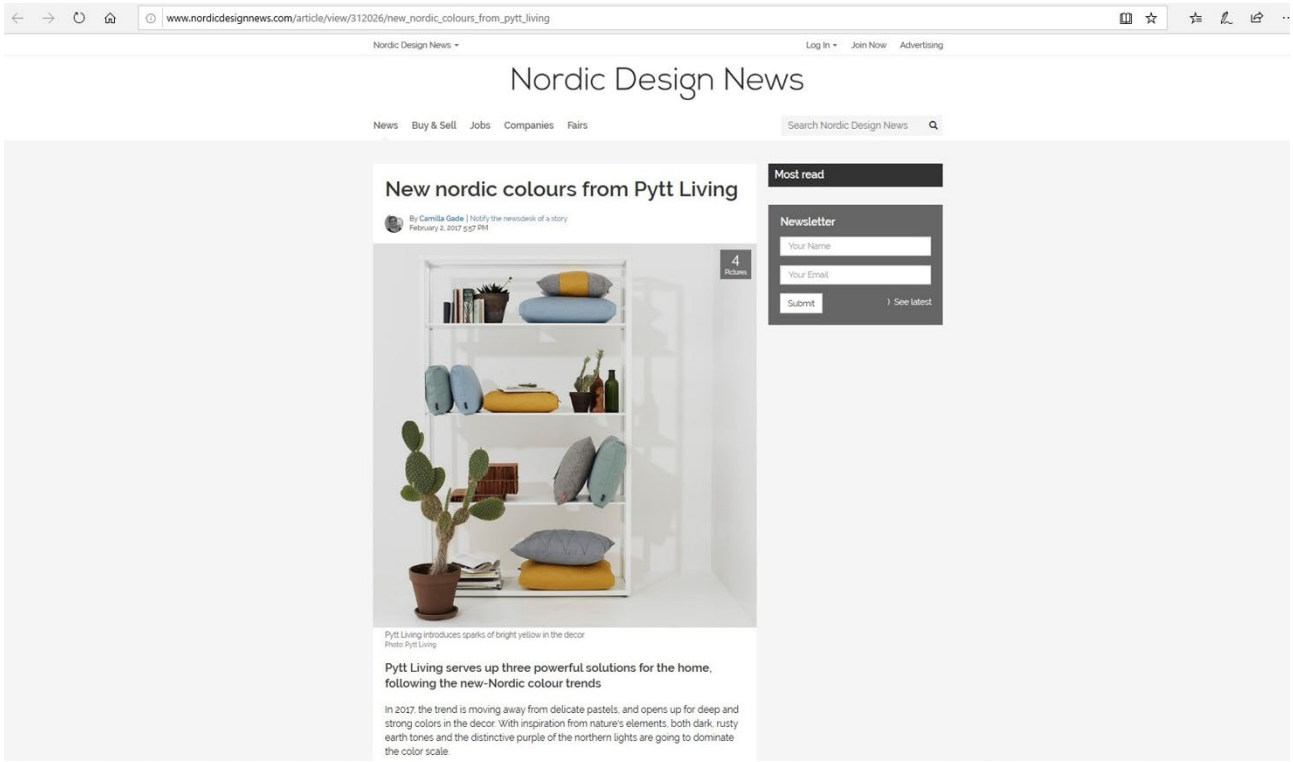


Figure 4. New Nordic colour scheme (see colours in online version of this article).

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Images, videos and infographics

On the Ørsted websites, photographic images, videos and infographics are centrally involved in the company's new visual identity, and, as I shall argue in the following, in establishing the three discourses under scrutiny here. While Ørsted's main areas of business are offshore wind, bioenergy and markets (i.e. the purchase, sale and distribution of energy), windmills take the lead as regards the company's visual representation of green energy. This is probably no surprise, since, over the years, windmills have acquired iconic status in this respect, as testified, for instance, by a simple search for "green energy" on internet image search services and image banks such as Google Images and Getty Images. Even so, I would argue that the images of windmills also play a role in Ørsted's corporate profits discourse because of the interpersonal choices made in their production (cf. Kress and van Leeuwen 2006, 114-53). Interpersonally, the windmills are typically represented either at a very long distance or at a close distance (cf. Kress and van Leeuwen 2006, 124-28). Where the former choice results in the representation of a large number of windmills in one frame, the latter positions the viewer so close to a windmill that only a fragment of it is seen. The windmills are thus represented in a way that foregrounds either their quantity or their size (cf. Figure 5, https://orsted.com/en/media/press-kit/images-and-logo, accessed 25.05.2020), thereby indirectly signifying something about their potential effectiveness, following the logic that many windmills and big windmills can produce a lot of electricity.



Figure 5. Represented quantity and size of Ørsted windmills.

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The use of close interpersonal distance that results in a significant foregrounding of size is very pronounced in a video placed just below the navigation menu of orsted.co.uk at the time of writing (www.youtube.com/watch?v=eubK7-uTxhU, accessed 25.05.2020). The message of the video is that big changes (such as saving the climate by changing the way we power the world) happen "little by little" and "one step at a time". The visual side of the video shows that in Ørsted's case, these small steps are perhaps not so small after all, since the video is full of close-ups of very big parts of what must logically be even bigger windmills. The extensive use of close interpersonal distance has the effect of showing the viewer how massive and technologically impressive the Ørsted windmills are, while at the same time, the voice-over establishes an explicit connection between "bigger" and "better" with the implication that both mean 'profitable'.

The corporate profits discourse is also manifest in the photos of people at work at Ørsted. These partipants are typically either a) characterised culturally through helmets, safety glasses and workwear and represented as engaged in active material processes of operating windmills or other machines, or b) characterised culturally by typical office wear (suits, shirts, blouses, etc.) and represented as working on laptops, talking on the phone, etc. in office settings (cf. Kress and van Leeuwen 2006, 45-75). In both groups of images, people are represented as participants involved in active (material or verbal) processes related to their job at Ørsted, thereby creating a sense of efficiency.

A different style of representation is seen in the presentation of Ørsted's Board of Directors (https://orsted.com/en/about-us/management/board-of-directors, accessed 25.02.2021) which includes portraits of the board members. While headshots are commonplace in such presentations, the more specific grammatical choices made in the photographs of the Ørsted board members make them distinctive. Where corporate board members are typically presented interpersonally in a frontal, eye-level, close-distance view with a direct gaze directed "at" the viewer, none of the represented Ørsted board members make a clear demand for interaction (through direct gaze) and many of them have a certain relaxation of their posture, realised by a slight canting of their head and/or body. Additionally, all board members are involved in the process of smiling. Through these choices the board members appear less formal and intimidating than is usually seen in official corporate headshots, thereby arguably foregrounding the personal and human. Furthermore, where official corporate headshots often display a neutral monochrome background (or "circumstances"), the background of the Ørsted images clearly carries more signification. By including a characteristic

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corporate setting of steel and glass as well as a significant amount of green plants and trees that can be seen through the glass, the background setting appears to subtly combine a corporate profits discourse and a green discourse.

The websites furthermore contain a considerable number of photographic images of what viewers must assume to be private individuals, possibly consumers of Ørsted's products and services. As regards their experiential contents, these photos fall into two groups: people in their homes and people involved in outdoor activities. The first group shows family situations in the home: a man changing a lightbulb, a couple in the kitchen, a woman sharing something on a mobile phone with a boy and a girl, a woman working at her computer, a boy placing (and perhaps drying) his toy cars on a radiator, etc. In the context of Ørsted's websites, the images appear to imply that the represented participants are consumers of Ørsted's products even if some of them are not explicitly shown to be using electricity and heating. It is characteristic of these images that they project everyday family situations, but there is nothing particularly 'green' about them. Instead, they align with the New Nordic discourse of contemporary lifestyle magazines with their display of popular Nordic design items such as a Bodum French press coffee maker, an Ursula jug, a Kubus candleholder and an Arne Jakobsen tap as well as interior designs that are recognisable from that context (e.g. Figure 6).

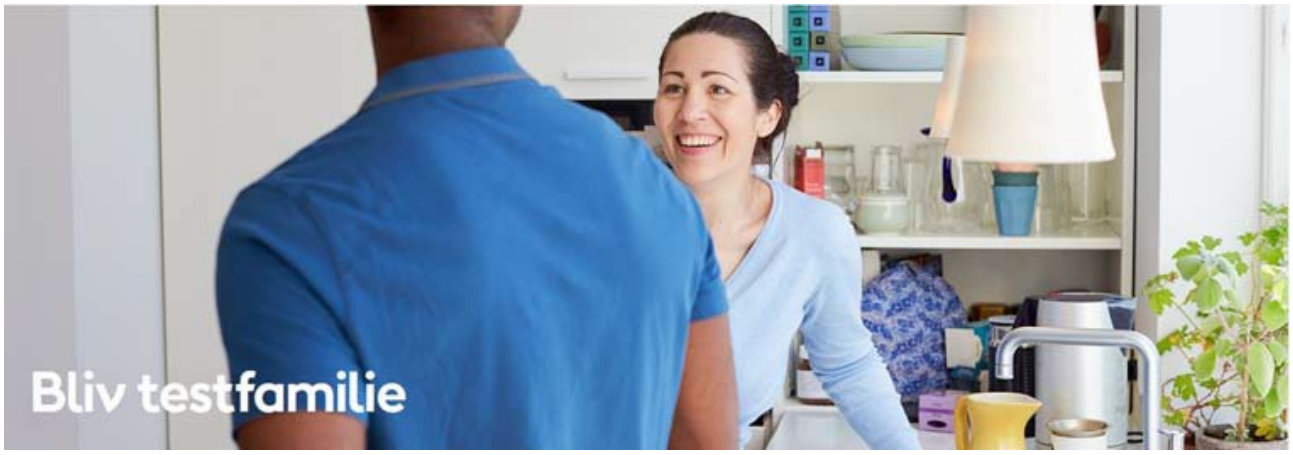


Figure 6. Represented family situation in the home on the Ørsted website.

In the second group of photographs, participants are not represented as engaging with Ørsted products but are involved in outdoor activities such as recreational fishing, jogging, riding a kick scooter, kite-

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flying, cycling or standing in the wind, often against a background of natural scenery or a vast amount of blue sky (cf. Figure 7). While some of these photographs have strong connotations of wind, others simply display people in a natural scenery, maybe suggestive of the kind of life that nature offers and which Ørsted claims to protect with its green transition. With the experiential prominence of nature in these images, they contribute to Ørsted's self-portrayal as a business with green concerns and hence to the sustainability discourse involved in the new brand image.

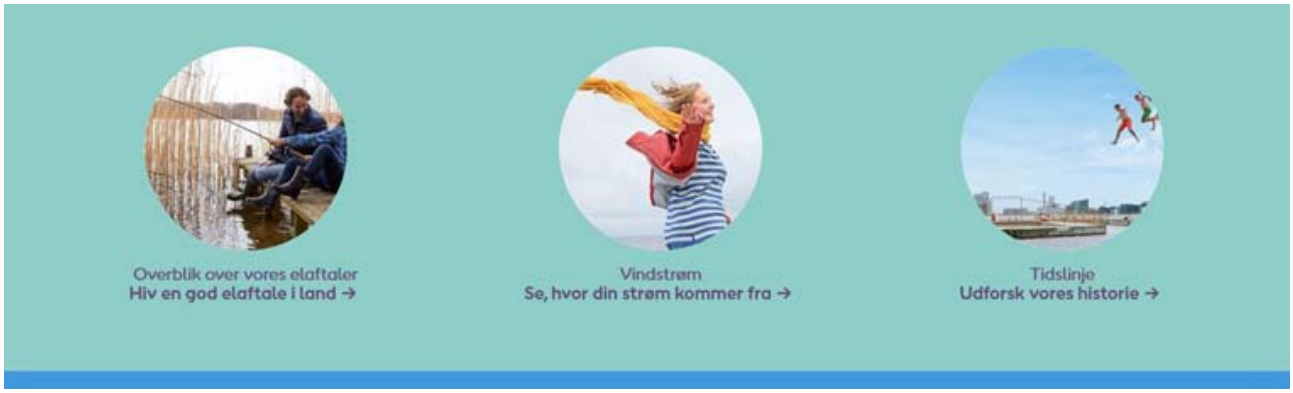


Figure 7. Represented outdoor activities on the Ørsted website.

The sustainability discourse is absolutely central in the corporate video used for launching the new brand (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=56MhjXTcSCg&t=12s, accessed 25.05.2020). The perceived significance of the video is reflected by its being placed on the landing page of most of the Ørsted websites – often in the prominent spot just below the top menu, sometimes further down the page – and by being allotted this important place in the website layout for almost two years following its launch. The message of the video pivots around a multimodally established metaphor of the world being our home. The sustainability discourse is constructed as a vacillation between positive and negative evaluation of nature through images, wording and sound. The video starts by establishing the metaphor of the world being our home through a series of beautiful – and hence positively evaluated – land-, mountain- and seascapes, described by the voice-over as the "rooms", "passages" and "top floor" of our home followed by the observation that "our home has treated us well." In this part of the video, the images are accompanied first by plucked strings in syncopated rhythms, giving an energetic lighthearted effect. Later that changes to a solo piano playing sustained chords which is joined by bowed strings playing accompanying long notes, moving in a tension-free harmony. This

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is followed by negatively evaluated images of the natural forces raging as a result of man-made climate changes – images of big waves, thunder and lightning, flooding, erosion, gales and melting ice – as well as images of burning gas, an exhaust pipe, an oil drill and heavy smoke billowing from a big chimney. Here the background music is characterised by suspensions and dissonance played by the bowed strings, creating a sonic tension that needs to be resolved, and the voice-over states that "it's time for us to change the way we treat it [i.e. the world]." The tension peaks in a significant moment of silence accompanied visually by a black screen. The last part of the video returns to positive evaluation, realised sonically by plucked strings, bowed strings and piano coming together in harmony and visually by images of elements caused to move by the wind (paper on a table, dandelion seeds, colourful kites, flapping sails, sea waves and windmill wings) intermeshed with images of children playing, an illuminated city and windmills under construction. This part of the video revolves around Ørsted's transformation from black to green and ends with a serene image of windmills against a quiet blue sea and sky and the superimposed text "Love your home" followed by the Ørsted logo and the slogan "Let's create a world that runs entirely on green energy." To judge from the video, the company attached importance to foregrounding the environmental sustainability of the new brand when it was first launched to the broad public. From a marketing perspective this was a sensible priority, since the focus on sustainability had the marketing value of being new and surprising in the context of an energy company which had until then primarily been known for its black activities.

Two other videos are worth mentioning here because of what they exclude. Both illustrate the journey of electricity from the windmills to the consumers. The first video shows a curious boy tracing an electric lead from electric light sources in his room, through the family garden, past other light sources at a football ground and a neighbouring garden party and all the way to the beach where the lead runs into the sea and out to an Ørsted windfarm (www.youtube.com/watch?v=v5_Jh7sd1SA, accessed 25.05.2020). The other video is a graphic illustration of the generation of electricity at offshore wind farms and its journey to the consumers (www.youtube.com/watch?v=xbuLc_nWfog, accessed 25.05.2020) via an offshore and an onshore substation from which it is shown to run directly into the homes of the consumers. While both videos are necessarily short, simplified illustrations, it is worth noting what is excluded from these multimodal narratives, i.e. the fact that the electricity does not run directly from the wind farms and into private homes, because, in actual fact, green energy is mixed with black energy before it reaches the consumers.

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In contrast to the two videos just described, the video, infographics and verbal text on one of Ørsted's Danish webpages for private customers presents a more honest version of the journey of the electricity from the windmills to the consumers by mentioning the mixture of green and black energy that it involves (https://privat.orsted.dk/el/kampagner/vindstroem-fra-orsted/#heading-32, accessed 25.05.2020). While this information is thus included on the Danish website, it is nevertheless backgrounded in two ways. First, the specific webpage is difficult to find since there is neither a link to it in the top menu nor in a submenu, which means that it can only be accessed from a link in the footer of the website. Second, the fact that the electricity that reaches the consumers is actually not green is legitimised by reference to abstract "green guarantees" that Ørsted produces just as much green electricity as the amount of (black and green) electricity that eventually reaches its customers.

The last visual aspect of the Ørsted website to be mentioned here is the use of infographics. The infographics consist of conventional graphic charts, icons and graphic illustrations of various issues. They are characterised by a simple modern style and are realised by the Ørsted colour scheme and typography, thereby contributing to the New Nordic discourse of the brand. At the same time, they also contribute significantly to Ørsted's sustainability discourse. The issues chosen for illustration are thus primarily issues that are related to the green transition of the company: its phase-out of coal, its growing offshore wind capacity, its decreasing carbon emissions, etc. In addition to this, many of the charts are designed so that the meaning of the bars of a bar chart is not just established by the accompanying wording and figures but also by visual experiential choices substituting plain bars with graphic representations of increasingly larger windmills, decreasing piles of coal, etc. The graphic illustrations often have a green twist as exemplified in Figure 8, where a leaf on the bottle in the middle indicates that the enzymes used for the conversion of household waste to energy are environmentally sound, just as the leaves at the end of the electric lead to the right signify the green nature of the electricity that results from the process.

While graphic charts are used extensively in Ørsted's annual report to illustrate the financial performance of the company, the profits discourse is neither very prominent nor very explicit in the Ørsted infographics online. An exception is the bar graph accompanying a list of the company's key figures (revenue, EBITDA, employees and power generation) shown in Figure 9 (https://orsted.com/en/Our-business/Offshore-wind, accessed 25.07.2019). In the icon to the left, the sustainability discourse appears to have colonised the company profits discourse with the graphic

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representation of a leaf overlapping the bar graph, thereby visually adding a green aspect to what would otherwise be pure signifiers of profits.

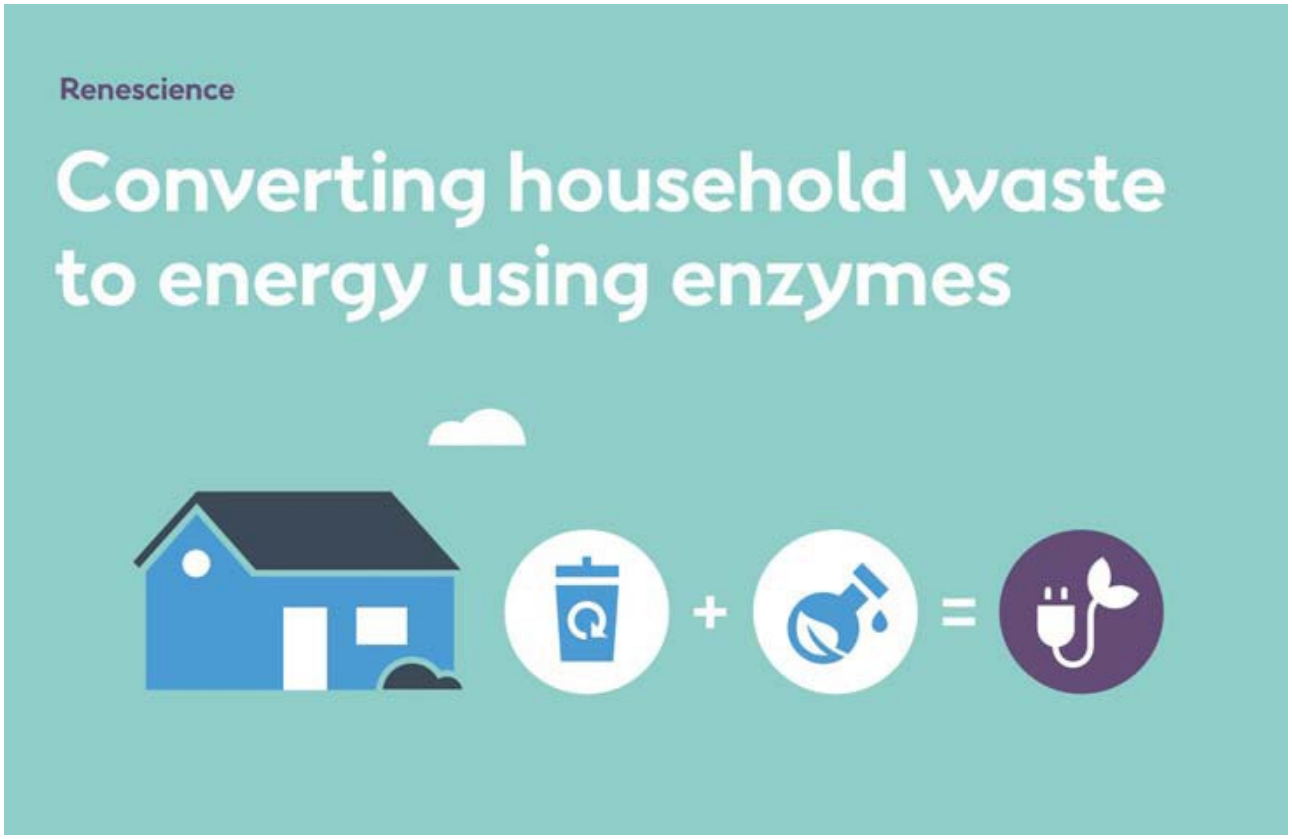


Figure 8. Graphic representation of 'renescience' process.

Although the profits discourse is not particularly noticeable in Ørsted's infographics online, it is arguably implicitly present in the graphic charts showing the growth of the company's green activities such as the increasing size and capacity of its offshore wind turbines from 1991 to the present (https://orsted.com/en/Our-business/Offshore-wind/Our-offshore-wind-capabilities, accessed 25.05.2020), the number of people powered by its offshore wind farms (https://orsted.com/en/Media/Press-kit/Fast-facts, accessed 25.05.2020), etc. To sum up, the three discourses examined here are all present in Ørsted's infographics, however the sustainability discourse is given high priority while the corporate profits discourse is virtually disguised as statements about sustainability.

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Figure 9. Graphic representation of Ørsted key figures 2018.

Concluding remarks

In my analysis, I have shown how the Ørsted brand is presented multimodally on the company websites and in the corporate discourse surrounding the brand. There can be no doubt that Ørsted is a company that has gone through a remarkable green transition – from energy production based on fossil fuels to more sustainable alternatives – and that to a large extent there is consistency between corporate image and identity. From an aesthetic perspective, the brand image is furthermore characterised by a consistent and well-executed multimodal design. Yet while environmentally sustainable aspects of Ørsted's activities are foregrounded in the new brand image, other elements are backgrounded and even excluded. As revealed by my analysis above, the fact that what consumers actually get from Ørsted is not green but a mixture of green and black energy is backgrounded and substituted by abstract "green guarantees." I have also shown how the Ørsted websites favour a sustainability discourse over a more backgrounded corporate profits discourse. Where the latter is used to legitimise the company's green transformation to stakeholders with a natural interest in profits on a limited number of webpages targeted at that specific group of users, it is far less prominent on the Ørsted websites more generally, where it is often couched in a sustainability discourse both visually and verbally.

An issue that is completely excluded from the new brand image and the corporate discourse about the brand is the fact that when Ørsted phased out upstream oil and gas production, the company did not shut down these black activities altogether but sold them to another player on the market, chemical industry giant Ineos. From a corporate perspective the sale is understandable, and not mentioning the sale on the website is arguably justified by oil and gas production no longer being part of Ørsted's

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portfolio. However, as observed by Tarjei Haarland, Greenpeace, the sale was "good for DONG but not for the climate" (Greenpeace 2016). Not only do the black activities continue after the sale but they are continued by a company with a questionable environmental track record in Europe and the US where it has been responsible for fires, explosions, leaking oil, gas and toxic chemicals (Food and Water Europe 2017).

Furthermore, it should be noted that although Ørsted prides itself of having phased out the production of fossil fuels, the company still buys and sells natural gas and thus contributes to the pollution and carbon emissions that this fossil fuel incurs. While less harmful to the environment than coal and oil, natural gas is not a renewable form of energy and can hardly be considered green in spite of the deceptive 'green' signification involved in its name.

Another energy source that has taken over from oil and coal in Ørsted's green transformation is wood biomass. Like "natural gas", "biomass" sounds green, however as with "natural gas" the name may be deceptive. While biomass is necessary for the phase-out of fossil fuels, the claim that it is a carbon neutral energy source is facing growing criticism. (e.g. Klimarådet 2018; Ambrose 2019). It is worth noting that although biomass currently makes up a substantial part of Ørsted's activities, this potentially controversial energy source is significantly less prominent visually on the company's websites than wind energy and is completely absent from the launch video analysed above.

Finally, very little is said on the Ørsted websites about the fact that although wind energy is green energy and does not damage the environment the way fossil fuels do, the production of wind energy is not sustainable over its entire life cycle. As pointed out by Vissanova (2016, 44-47), the disposal of the wind turbine blades is a challenge from an environmental perspective since the materials of which they consist are toxic and cannot be recycled but must be incinerated or landfilled. With a reference to UN World Sustainability Goal number 12, "Responsible consumption and production", a statement of good intentions is made at the Ørsted website: "We aim to decrease company impacts on the environment by improving the reuse and recycling of waste generated in our operations and reducing hazardous waste rates" (https://orsted.com/en/Sustainability/Our-strategy/Enabling-sustainable-growth). It is worth noting, however, that possible direct mention of e.g. the disposal of the turbine blades is substituted by more abstract "company impacts on the environment" and "hazardous waste rates" which Ørsted "*aims*" (my emphasis) to "decrease" and "reduce". No matter how good the intentions may be, the actual commitments expressed in this way are vague as regards the specific *kind* of waste and the *amounts* by which Ørsted commits to reducing it. Altogether, talk

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of waste from Ørsted's operations is generally backgrounded on the website where the quote above, for example, is found in an accordion menu on a subpage about sustainability.

"Let's create a world that runs entirely on green energy" the Ørsted slogan proclaims. This is a vision so bold that a fair amount of criticism might be expected in the media and elsewhere – not least in view of the discursive exclusions I have pointed out in my analysis above. Even so, critical voices have been surprisingly few and far between since the new brand was first launched. This may be owing to Ørsted's green transition being so obviously a significant step in a more sustainable direction, however the possibility cannot be ruled out that the multimodal construction of the new brand image has also played a role in this respect with its predominant sustainability discourse, spiced up by an aesthetically pleasing touch of New Nordic. It is important to see through such discourses to make sure that well-executed branding strategies – including a cool design and strategic talk of environmental sustainability – do not cause consumers, politicians and others to forget the environmental challenges that still exist. In this article, I have shown how MCDA offers analytical tools that allow us to do so.

I would like to thank Ørsted and Kontrapunkt for giving me permission to reproduce images and screenshots from their websites and Camilla Gade for permission to use a screenshot of her blog post from "Nordic Design News".

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[1] The terms "Scandinavian" and "Nordic" are often used interchangeably. As pointed out by Sandbye (2016, 2), "The New Nordic" has been a prevalently used term since the early 2000s.